SEALED PAPERS · SPOILERS

The complete route

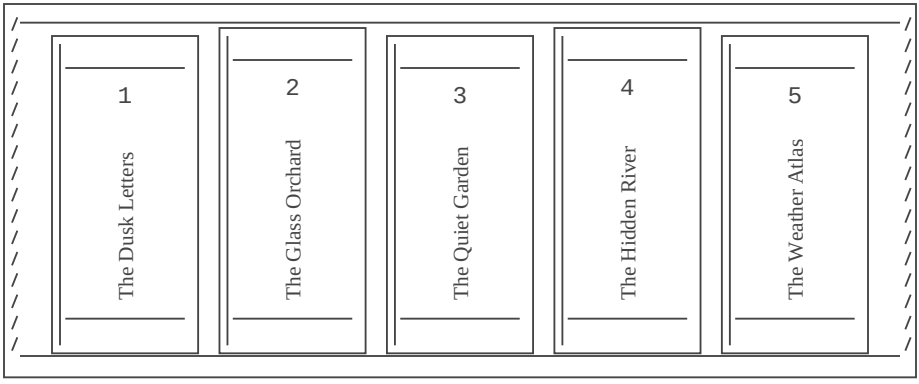
NORTH · THE QUIET GARDEN

CLOCK · 1105

The letter

The five lines start with **N, O, R, T, H**. In order, the initials point to the NORTH shelf. The reference to a “beginning” directs attention to the first letters.

The shelf



The adjacent pairs are Glass Orchard / Quiet Garden and Hidden River / Weather Atlas. The first pair must precede the second, and Dusk Letters must precede Glass Orchard. These conditions fix the row. Its middle book is **The Quiet Garden**.

SEALED PAPERS · CONTINUED

The object and combination

The catalogue

The Quiet Garden’s inscription is **XOLXP**. Mirroring the alphabet gives X → C, O → L, L → O, X → C and P → K: **CLOCK**. The drawer is in the clock’s wooden base.

The work log

Start	09:45
Archive plates: +22 minutes	10:07
Shelf labels: +17 minutes	10:24
Wrapped papers: +26 minutes	10:50
Wooden base: +15 minutes	11:05

The tasks take 80 minutes. The finishing time is **11:05**. Removing the colon gives **1105**; both minute digits are required.

The first folio is in the drawer beneath the reading-room clock. The papers identify its shelf, book and object before providing the combination.

EPILOGUE

The first unwritten hour

The brass wheels settle beneath your fingertips. For a moment, nothing moves. Then the latch gives, softly enough to be mistaken for another tick.

Inside the clock’s base is a narrow paper parcel. Ada lifts it into the lamplight. The ribbon leaves a clean stripe across the brown wrapping, as if the years have collected everywhere except the place someone took care to protect.

There is one title page, written in a small, deliberate hand: *A Map of Unwritten Hours*. Below it stands the name Elias Rowan. A pencilled sentence waits at the bottom: “For anyone who has ever found the right door inside the wrong book.”

A second note is in Elsie’s hand. “People called the manuscript lost because they were looking for one finished object. Elias left it in six gatherings. This is the first. I kept his trail because I wanted the next keeper to discover the shop as he did: by paying attention.”

Ada turns the page. The first paragraph describes a city whose library lends hours instead of books. An hour of courage. An hour of forgiveness. An hour to say what should have been said before the door closed.

Outside, the evening’s first visitor pauses beneath the shop sign. Ada carefully lays the folio on the archive table. There are five more gatherings to find. For tonight, though, the oldest story in Bellwether Books has finally reached a reader.

A Map of Unwritten Hours

by Elias Rowan

There was a city where the library lent hours instead of books. Its shelves held small, plain volumes with names such as *An Hour of Courage* and *An Hour to Begin Again*. Nobody was allowed to borrow an hour for another person, and nobody could keep one past sunrise.

On the morning the clocks stopped, a girl named Mara returned an empty volume. The librarian turned it over twice. “What did you do with the hour?” he asked. Mara looked towards the door, where someone had been waiting for a very long time. “I listened,” she said.



The first folio is safe.
Five gatherings remain.